

CASE ID: 201204710740

EPISODE NAME: China Threatens Japan Over Senkaku Island Nationalization

2012/04/17 - 2013/09/10

Sender: China (710)

Target: Japan (740)

Issue: Solve Territorial Dispute (5)

Final Outcome: Stalemate in Threat Stage (4)

Summary:

On 2012/04/17, China threatened Japan after Tokyo's nationalist governor Shintaro Ishihara announced plans for the city to buy the disputed Senkaku (or Diaoyu) islands from a private owner.¹ After the national Japanese government eventually announced it had decided to buy the islands instead of Tokyo on 2012/09/10,² China threatened economic sanctions³ and cancelled a symbolic event celebrating 40 years of peaceful Sino-Japanese relations.⁴ Beijing never followed through on threats of economic retaliation, likely due to the country's close trading relationship with Japan.⁵

Narrative:

The episode began on 2012/04/17, when Chinese officials protested Tokyo governor Shintaro Ishihara's announcement that the city planned to purchase the disputed Senkaku (Diaoyu) Islands from a private owner.⁶ Ishihara is a Japanese nationalist known for making provocative political statements.⁷ The islands are surrounded by important fishing grounds and natural resources.⁸

On 2012/05/23, amidst rising tensions, China cancelled general Guo Boxiong's visit to Japan.⁹

In what some news outlets described as an effort to de-escalate tensions, Japan's prime minister announced on 2012/07/07 that the national government, rather than Tokyo, would pursue

¹ "Tokyo to buy disputed islands, says Governor Ishihara." 17 April 2012, *BBC News*.

<https://www.bbc.com/news/world-asia-17747934>

² Talmadge, Eric. "China reacts to Japan's plans to buy islands claimed by China and Taiwan." 10 Sept. 2012, *Christian Science Monitor*.

<https://www.csmonitor.com/World/Latest-News-Wires/2012/0910/China-reacts-to-Japan-s-plans-to-buy-islands-claimed-by-China-and-Taiwan>

³ Lim, Louisa. "China Ratchets Up The Rhetoric In Island Spat With Japan." 17 Sept. 2012, NPR.

<https://www.npr.org/sections/thetwo-way/2012/09/18/161271408/china-ratchets-up-the-rhetoric-in-island-spat-with-japan>

⁴ Associated Press. "China cancel diplomatic events with Japan amid islands row." 23 Sept. 2012, *The Guardian*.

<https://www.theguardian.com/world/2012/sep/23/islands-row-china-japan>

⁵ Ford, Peter. "China and Japan face off: Tiny islands, big dispute." 12, Oct. 2012, *Christian Science Monitor*.

<https://www.csmonitor.com/World/Asia-Pacific/2012/1002/China-and-Japan-face-off-Tiny-islands-big-dispute>

⁶ "Tokyo to buy disputed islands, says Governor Ishihara." 17 April 2012, *BBC News*.

<https://www.bbc.com/news/world-asia-17747934>

⁷ *Ibid.*

⁸ *Ibid.*

⁹ Wong, Edward. "China: General's Trip to Japan Is Canceled." 23 May, 2012.

<https://www.nytimes.com/2012/05/24/world/asia/china-generals-trip-to-japan-is-canceled.html>

purchasing the disputed islands.¹⁰ On 2012/09/10, the government confirmed the negotiations were complete and that it would proceed with the purchase.¹¹ China responded the same day, saying Japan would face “serious consequences” if it proceeded with the proposal.¹² Soon after, Chinese state media began to threaten that Japan would face another “lost decade” of economic stagnation if China imposed sanctions.¹³

China canceled a ceremonial event marking 40 years of diplomatic relations with Japan on 2012/09/23, saying they needed to be held “at a proper time.”¹⁴ However, there are no reports that China followed through on imposing economic sanctions. Some accounts suggest this restraint reflected the high potential cost to China, as Japan was China’s second-largest investor, contributing roughly \$5 billion in the first eight months of 2012.¹⁵

¹⁰ Sieg, Linda. “Japan plan to buy disputed isles risks China's ire.” 10 July, 2012.

<https://www.reuters.com/article/amp/idUSBRE86907920120710/>

¹¹ Talmadge, Eric. “China reacts to Japan's plans to buy islands claimed by China and Taiwan.” 10 Sept. 2012, *Christian Science Monitor*.

<https://www.csmonitor.com/World/Latest-News-Wires/2012/0910/China-reacts-to-Japan-s-plans-to-buy-islands-claimed-by-China-and-Taiwan>

¹² *Ibid.*

¹³ Lim, Louisa. “China Ratchets Up The Rhetoric In Island Spat With Japan.” 17 Sept. 2012, *NPR*.

<https://www.npr.org/sections/thetwo-way/2012/09/18/161271408/china-ratchets-up-the-rhetoric-in-island-spat-with-japan>

¹⁴ Associated Press. “China cancel diplomatic events with Japan amid islands row.” 23 Sept. 2012, *The Guardian*.

<https://www.theguardian.com/world/2012/sep/23/islands-row-china-japan>

¹⁵ Ford, Peter. “China and Japan face off: Tiny islands, big dispute.” 12, Oct. 2012, *Christian Science Monitor*.

<https://www.csmonitor.com/World/Asia-Pacific/2012/1002/China-and-Japan-face-off-Tiny-islands-big-dispute>